// AI BUILDER · SESSION 3 · COLLEGE DATA

Price vs. Payoff

What three New York-area colleges return per tuition-dollar, and what to check before trusting a low price

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For prospective students & families

// AGENDA

The national picture, three schools, one checklist

01  **The national picture**
College pays on average, but net price, program and completion decide it
Slides 3-7

02  **Three schools, three catches**
NYU's value, Hunter's completion rate, Rutgers-Newark's state baseline
Slides 8-12

03  **What to check**
Completion and debt, then four numbers to compare any options
Slides 13-14

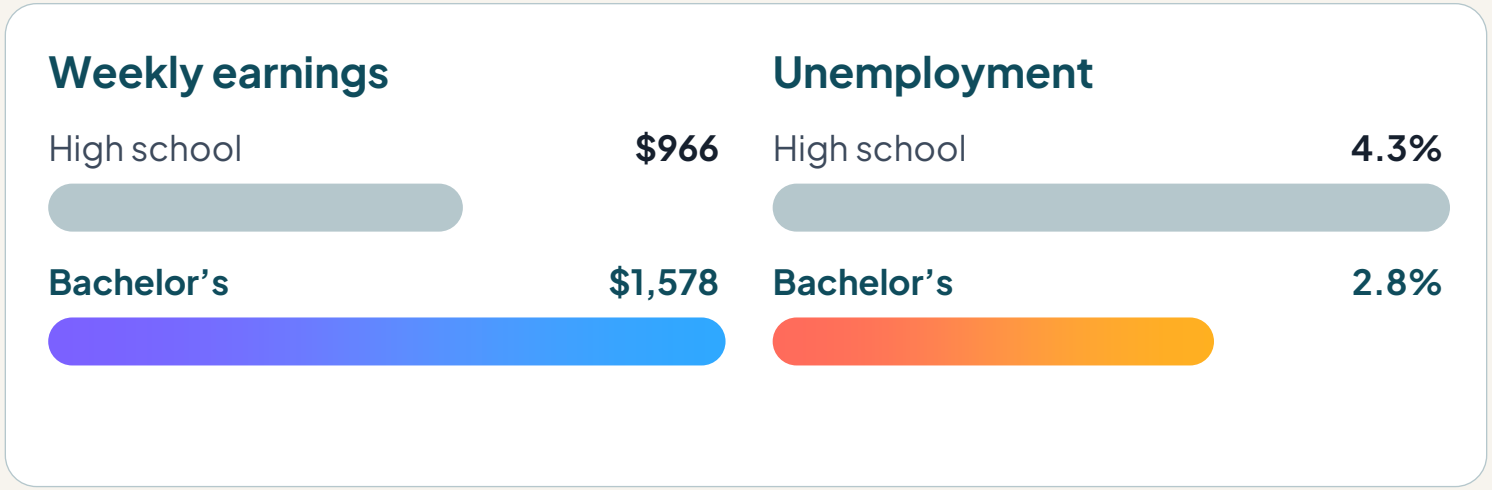
Sources: BLS, NCES, College Board, Georgetown CEW, NY Fed, College Scorecard

A bachelor's degree still pays: about 63% more per week than a high school diploma

WEEKLY EARNINGS PREMIUM

+63%

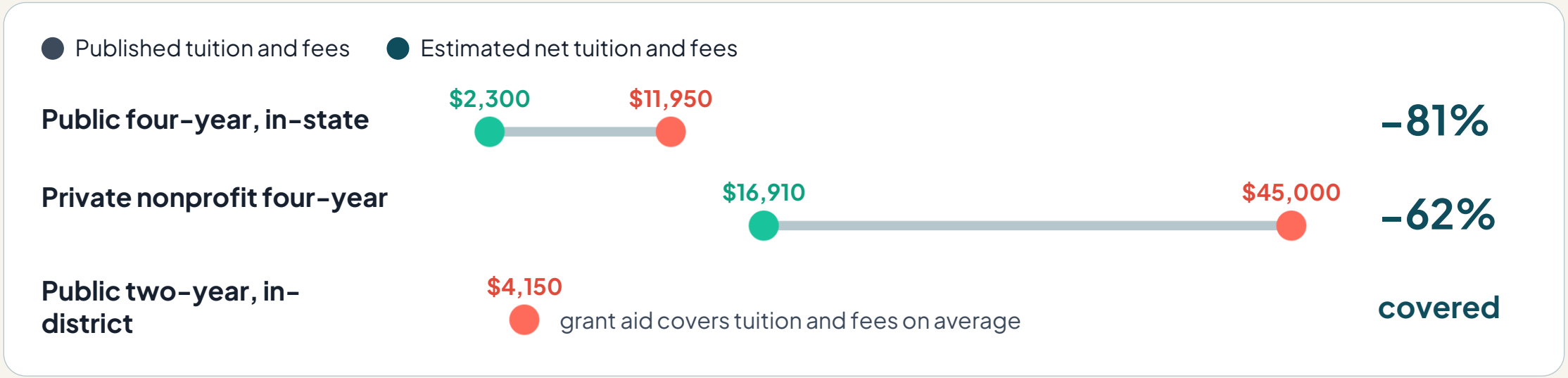
$1,578 vs. $966 a week (BLS, 2025)



The gap shows up for young workers too: full-time workers ages 25–34 with a bachelor's earned $66,600 a year versus $41,800 for high school completers, 59% more (2022 dollars).

Sources: BLS, Education Pays (2025, 11-month average excluding October); NCES, Condition of Education

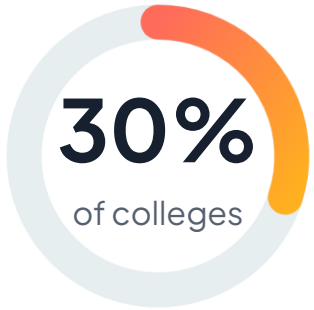
Most families don’t pay sticker price: public four-year net tuition is about $2,300



Source: College Board, Trends in College Pricing and Student Aid (2025-26 published prices; net price estimates, first-time full-time students)

At 30% of colleges, more than half of students earn less than a high school graduate ten years out

COLLEGES AFFECTED



1,233 of about 4,500 ranked

Ten-year value by program type

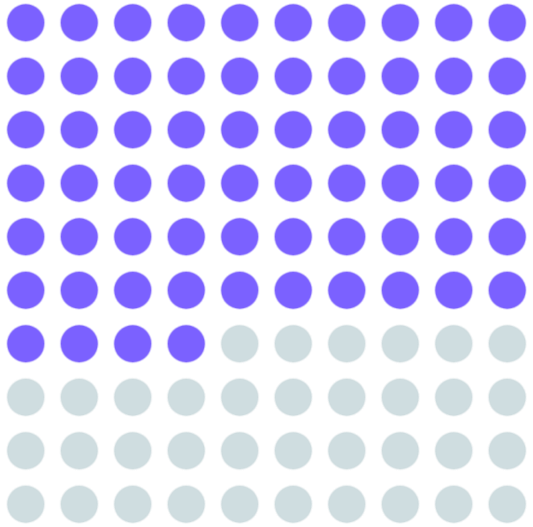


The order flips over a career: at 40 years, bachelor's programs lead with a median value of $864,000. The payoff depends on the program and the time horizon.

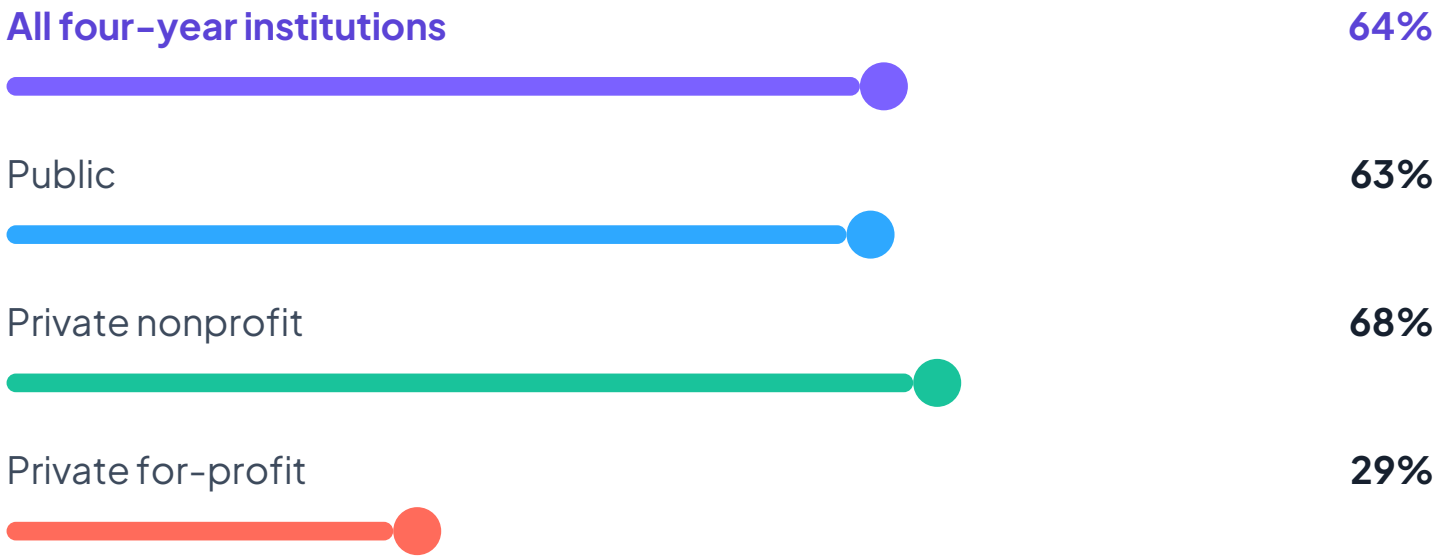
Source: Georgetown CEW ROI database (1,233 colleges); median net present value by degree level, A First Try at ROI (2019)

Finishing is the swing factor: only 64% of bachelor's students graduate within six years

64 of every 100 students finish



Six-year graduation rate by school type



Ask each school for its graduation rate before comparing prices.

Source: NCES, six-year graduation rate, first-time full-time bachelor's students who started in fall 2014 (graduating from the same school)

Even a finished degree carries risk: 42% of recent graduates are underemployed

UNEMPLOYMENT



recent graduates, about, Q2 2026

UNDEREMPLOYMENT



of recent graduates, Q2 2026

LOAN DELINQUENCY



of student-loan balances, Q1 2026

In Q1 2026 about 2.6 million borrowers, more than 120 days past due, were moved to the Education Department's default resolution group.

Sources: NY Fed, Labor Market for Recent College Graduates (Q2 2026); NY Fed household debt report, Q1 2026

// PRICE VS. PAYOFF

A $7,382 college returns more than six times as much per tuition-dollar as a $62,796 one

CUNY Hunter College · $7,382 tuition

$2.14

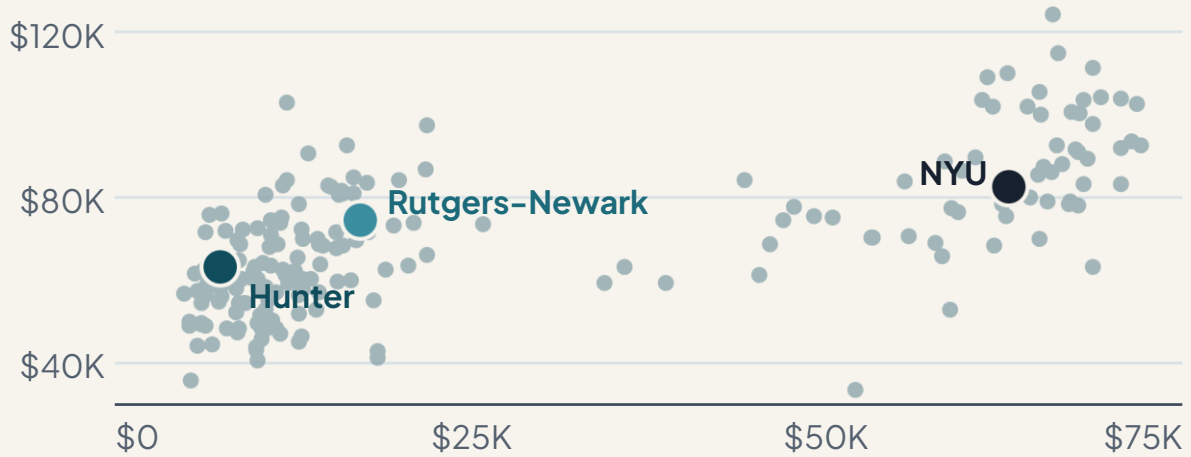
earnings per $1 of four-year tuition

New York University · $62,796 tuition

$0.33

earnings per $1 of four-year tuition

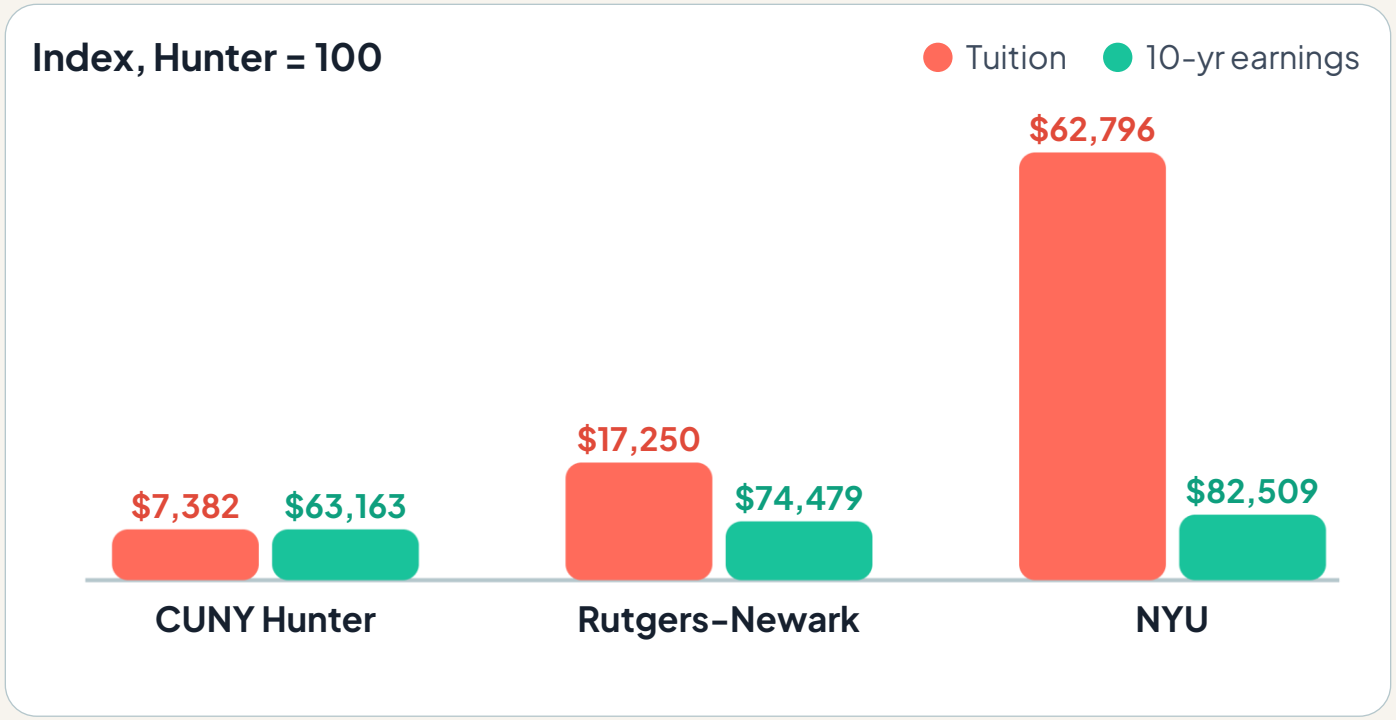
Each dot is one of 200 schools



Across: in-state tuition per year · Up: 10-year median earnings

Three colleges compared with 200 schools · Source: College Scorecard, in college-analysis.xlsx

Tuition differs 8.5x, but earnings differ only 31%



8.5x

NYU tuition vs. Hunter ($62,796 vs. $7,382)

1.3x

NYU earnings vs. Hunter ($82,509 vs. $63,163)

Hunter and Rutgers-Newark at in-state tuition · Earnings: median 10 years after entry, federal-aid recipients · Source: College Scorecard

NYU is the 16th hardest school to get into, yet ranks 176th of 199 on value

ADMISSION RATE



16th most selective of 200

10-YEAR EARNINGS



$82,509 median, top quarter

RETURN PER TUITION-$



$0.33 per $1 vs. $1.11 average

The 55 schools charging over $50,000 a year average $87,174 in earnings, $4,665 more than NYU. Its 88.0% completion rate does beat that group's 86.2%.

Admission ring = rate; other rings = percentile among schools · Value uses sticker price, not aid · Source: College Scorecard

Hunter’s bargain has a catch: only 58.8% of students finish

RETURN PER TUITION-$



$2.14 per $1 vs. $1.11 average

DEBT BURDEN



22nd lowest of 200 · tick = average 30.3%

STUDENTS WHO FINISH

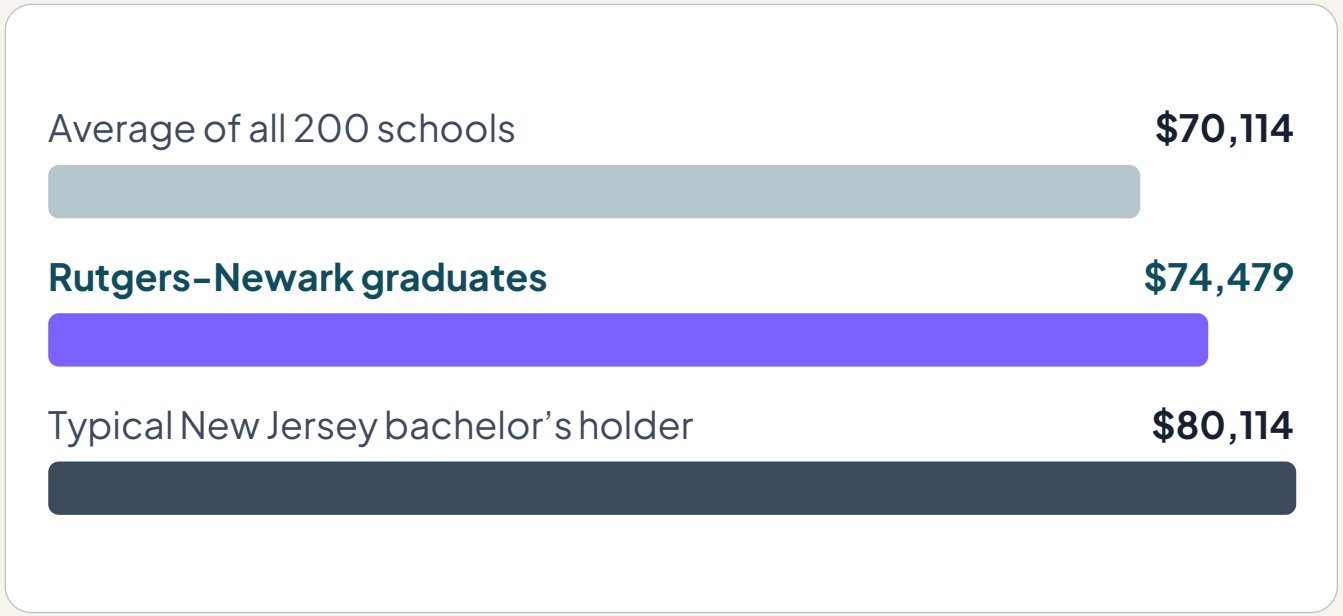


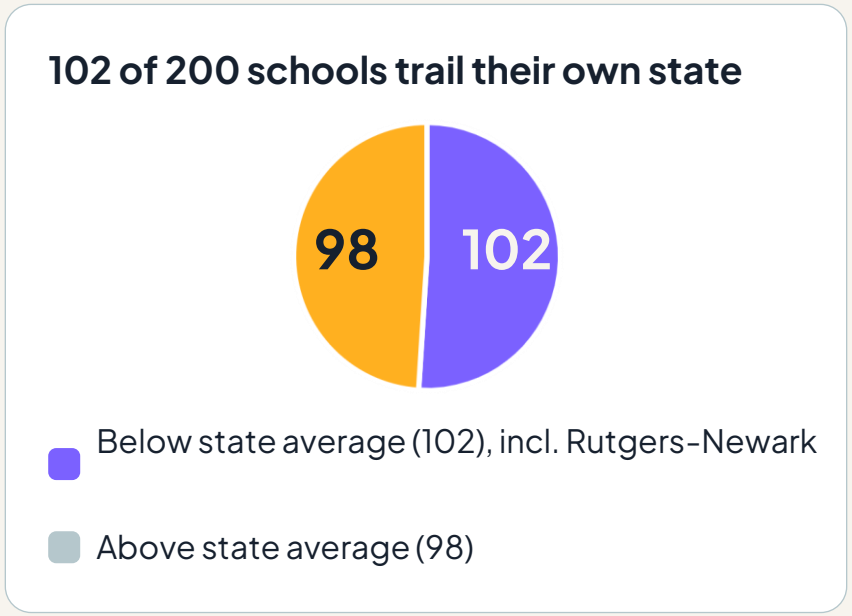
153rd of 200 · tick = average 72.5%

Top-20 value and a light debt load sit next to a bottom-quarter completion rate. The data shows the pattern, not the reason, so ask the school why.

Value ring = percentile among 199 schools · Debt burden = median debt ÷ 10-yr median earnings · Source: College Scorecard, in college-analysis.xlsx

Rutgers–Newark beats the average school but not its own state





Rutgers-Newark falls $5,635 short of its state baseline, 131st of 200, in the slightly larger half of schools that trail theirs. Debt is the pressure point: $21,500 median, the highest of the three schools.

10-year median earnings vs. state bachelor's median (Census) · Source: College Scorecard, in college-analysis.xlsx

Before calling a school a bargain, check completion rate and debt burden

SCHOOL	FINISH RATE	DEBT BURDEN
CUNY Hunter	**58.8%**	**17.4%**
NYU	**88.0%**	**24.8%**
Rutgers–Newark	**65.7%**	**28.9%**
Average, 200 schools	72.5%	30.3%

Ask every school for both numbers

1. What share of students finish?
2. How much do graduates borrow compared with what they earn?

Finish rate = completion rate (higher is better). Debt burden = median debt ÷ 10-year median earnings (lower is better). Sticker prices ignore aid.

Earnings are for graduates who received federal aid · Source: College Scorecard, in college-analysis.xlsx

Compare at least three options before committing, using four numbers

01

Net price

What you pay after grants, not the published price.

02

Graduation rate

The share who finish at that school; low rates raise the risk.

03

Earnings after ten years

What graduates of that program earn a decade out.

04

Debt vs. earnings

Typical borrowing compared with what graduates earn.

Next step: look up your shortlist in the U.S. Department of Education's College Scorecard and line the four numbers up side by side.

Sources: BLS; NCES; College Board; Georgetown CEW; NY Fed; U.S. Department of Education College Scorecard